

crore company contributing over 80 per cent of India's oil and gas production. These commercially viable discoveries also ended ONGC's dependence on Government coffers which had funded its efforts since its inception. By 1982, public funding had touched Rs 343 crore. "That was the last tranche. Since then, whatever wealth creation we have done is with our own resources," says Sharma. With 240 production installations, 70 drilling rigs and 147 well platforms, ONGC owns and operates more than 15,000 km of pipelines in India including nearly 3,800 km of sub-sea pipelines. These assets have helped ONGC with more than 300 discoveries of oil and gas and establish 6.61 billion tonnes of in-place hydrocarbon reserves. They also drive the company's net profit of Rs 16,126 crore and a 14.49 per cent compounded annual growth rate of its turnover. This year too, it has incurred the highest ever capital expenditure of Rs 21,820 crore. "This all has," according to Sharma, "put ONGC firmly on the global radar screen as a oil producing entity".

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discoveries were made in the hydrocarbon sector in India during the last decade.

The biggest wealth creation, however, is ONGC's self-reliance and development of core competence in exploration and production activities. Its wholly-owned subsidiary, ONGC Videsh Ltd. (OVL), is the biggest Indian multi-national with a commitment of overseas investment of over \$5 billion in 44 oil and gas projects in 18 countries including Vietnam, Sudan, Russia, Iraq, Iran, Myanmar, Egypt and Brazil. "But that's not where the road ends," says Sharma. Plans are already in place. Worried over depleting domestic oil production, which has been stagnant at around 24-25 million tonnes in recent years and with an equally dismal current gas output at about 62 mmscmd, ONGC will invest over Rs

50,000 crore to develop new oil and gas fields and increase output from existing ones. This investment will help ONGC realise the projected 15 per cent increase in its oil production to 29 million tonnes in 2012-13 and an over 60 per cent jump in natural gas output to 100 million standard cubic metres per day by 2014-15. On the cards is also an aggressive push towards diversification into nuclear energy, the next big wealth multiplier. For this venture, ONGC has

also zeroed in on a location in Assam for uranium mining and has submitted a proposal to Uranium Corporation of India Ltd. for conducting joint exploration exercise.

"No doubt, all this will need a lot of sacrifices," says Sharma, whose family life has been the biggest casualty of his whirlwind work. But for the man who eats, sleeps and wakes up with oil, it's like living his dream.

by Nivedita Mukherjee

ONGC's deep water well under the Sagar Samridhi Project

